Jessica Mendes Ford
Dr. Micah Bateman
SLIS 5400
6 May 2026

Grant Proposal: Capoeira America Community Archive Online (CACAO)

1. Project Overview/Introduction

This project, Capoeira America Community Archive Online (CACAO), proposes a digital community archive for people engaged in the evolving tradition, culture, and practice of capoeira in the United States. This archive will serve as a centralized online hub where practitioners, researchers, and the broader public can discover digitized artifacts that preserve ephemera related to events, music, and stories central to capoeira across academies in the United States.

CACAO's mission is to ensure current and future capoeiristas and researchers can access artifacts, such as song lyrics, music, and records of batizados and other community events, preserving how the art form has evolved across US academies over several decades. Without coordinated preservation, these materials, currently dispersed across personal social media and private storage, are at high risk of loss, fragmentation, or platform-dependent disappearance.

CACAO aligns with competency 8B by challenging dominant archival systems through the documentation of an Afro-Brazilian cultural expression that has historically been marginalized. It aligns with competency 8D, incorporating social justice through outreach and partnerships with local academies to ensure community-led documentation and decision-making.

2. Project Justification

Capoeira traditions are largely intangible and ephemeral. Currently, the American capoeira community is underdocumented because academies often share photos, videos, flyers, and other ephemera on individual members' social media accounts, primarily Facebook, Instagram, and YouTube. Back-up copies, if they exist, are typically stored on personal cloud storage controlled by instructors or individual members. As practitioners relocate, groups evolve, or platforms change, this distributed record is unstable and easily lost.

CACAO responds to this gap by documenting the unique ways capoeira has evolved as a community-based cultural practice in the US, collecting and preserving ephemeral memory objects that might otherwise disappear. Although some projects document capoeira's broader cultural heritage, existing institutional archives often fail to capture localized practices, oral traditions, and community-specific histories, resulting in archival silences around the development of capoeira across US academies.

American capoeira academies bring together practitioners from diverse backgrounds, forming communities centered on learning, cultural exchange, and mutual support. Recognizing the importance of

trust and relationships, CACAO adopts a participatory archive model as a core value, allowing contributors to submit materials, describe them using community-defined metadata, and retain cultural ownership through post-custodial agreements. The project will build partnerships, conduct targeted outreach, and facilitate virtual and in-person engagement to connect loosely affiliated groups through a shared platform for discovery and contribution.

Unlike traditional archives, CACAO positions itself as an active, living infrastructure embedded within the communities it serves. The project operates through a post-custodial model, ensuring materials are preserved without being removed from community ownership or control. In doing so, CACAO engages in archival activism by creating space for Afro-Brazilian heritage within US archival landscapes that have historically privileged institutional and state records.

In addition to preservation, CACAO will activate its collections as educational tools. Digitized records, including song lyrics, rhythms, and regional histories, will support teaching and learning within academies, while community-led digital exhibitions will visualize the geographic spread and evolution of capoeira across US cities. By combining preservation, access, and activation, the archive functions not only as a repository but as a resource for cultural continuity and community connection.

3. Project Work Plan

Phase 1: Foundation & Governance (Months 1-4)

- Establish partnerships with initial collaborators, including Canto do Galo Capoeira Academy (Denver, CO) and Capoeira Brazilian Pelourinho (Orlando, FL)
- Form a Community Advisory Board composed of archival staff and representatives from partner academies
- Define collecting priorities, ethical protocols, and a digital preservation strategy
- Select and configure digital platforms and tools (e.g., Omeka)

Phase 2: Outreach & Collection (Month 5-18)

- Activate partnerships and conduct outreach through scheduled collection events (minimum of four per site; goal of once per quarter)
- Implement remote submission workflows for distributed participation
- Collect materials including oral histories, recordings of rodas and batizaods, musical audio, and digitized ephemera such as event flyers
- Establish acquisition workflows, contributor agreements, and documentation practices
- Conduct basic processing, description, and organization of materials (prioritizing access over intensive item-level processing)

Phase 3: Preservation, Access, & Sustainability(Months 19-24)

- Finalize and launch public-facing digital platform
- Conduct ethical review processes to protect sensitive community knowledge
- Develop plans for continued outreach, education (e.g., virtual workshops), and long-term collection growth

4. Social/Community Impact

The CACAO project provides current and future capoeira practitioners and researchers with access to a shared, community-generated historical record. By enabling practitioners to document their own lineages, traditions, and experiences, the archive supports community self-representation and reduces reliance on external documentation. The archive also strengthens connections across geographically dispersed academies, allowing participants to access shared cultural materials for teaching, learning, and community-building. For example, mestres and students can draw on archived songs, recordings, and event documentation to support learning and preserve lineage knowledge. By establishing a sustainable, community-controlled infrastructure, CACAO preserves cultural memory while intervening in systems that have historically marginalized Afro-Brazilian cultural expression.

5. Project Results

- CACAO digital platform: a fully functional, public-facing digital repository
- Collection growth: 300+ items over 24 months
- Partnership network: at least two formal academy partnerships
- Governance documentation: ethical review standards and community-defined metadata protocols

6. Budget Summary

Category	*Description*	*Target $ Amount*
Personnel	Archival staff and community liaison stipends	$68,000
Digital Infrastructure	Hosting, software (e.g., Omeka), and storage	$10,000
Outreach & Travel	Site visits and community events	$8,000
Equipment	Mobile digitization kits	$10,000
Administrative	Agreements, ethical consultation	$4,000
Total Requested		***$100,000***